

EYEWITNESS July 2, 1863

Little Round Top

On the second day of the Battle of Gettysburg, the Union defense extended from Culp's Hill, around Cemetery Hill, and along Cemetery Ridge. The stone-strewn hillside of Little Round Top served as the Union's left flank and the 20th Maine was its last line of defense. After battling repeated Confederate assaults, the regiment, low on ammunition, men, and energy, leveled their bayonets in a desperate counterattack.

"When 130 of our brave officers and men had been shot down where they stood, and only 178 remained—hardly more than a strong skirmish line—and each man had fired the 60 rounds of cartridges he carried into the fight, and the survivors were using from the cartridge-boxes of their fallen comrades, the time had come when it must be decided whether we should fall back and give up this key to the whole field of Gettysburg, or charge and try and throw off this foe. Colonel Chamberlain gave the order to 'fix bayonets,' and almost before he could say 'charge' the regiment leaped down the hill and closed in with the foe, whom we found behind every rock and tree. Surprised and overwhelmed, most of them threw down their arms and surrendered.

Some fought till they were slain; the others ran 'like a herd of wild cattle,' as Colonel Oates himself expressed it."

H. S. MELCHER, 20TH MAINE INFANTRY, FROM *BATTLES AND LEADERS OF THE CIVIL WAR*, 1888

"I ordered my regiment to change direction to the left, swing around, and drive the Federals from the ledge of rocks, for the purpose of enfilading their line ... gain the enemy's rear, and drive him from the hill. My men obeyed and advanced about half way to the enemy's position, but the fire was so destructive that my line wavered like a man trying to walk against a strong wind, and then slowly, doggedly, gave back a little ... We drove the Federals from their strong defensive position; five times they rallied and charged us, twice coming so near that some of my men had to use the bayonet, but in vain was their effort ... The Maine regiment charged my line, coming right up in a